

Custody Filing Procedure

Internal reference for the paralegal team

Internal reference for organizing custody filings at a family law firm. Template language only; client matters stay in the case system, not in this file.

Scope

This guide standardizes how the paralegal team opens, builds, and files a custody matter so that any document can be found in seconds and no service window is missed. The same standard carries into adoption documentation, where consent and home study records follow the identical structure.

Opening the matter folder

- Open every matter with the same folder skeleton and naming convention.
- Separate pleadings, correspondence, financials, and exhibits from day one.
- Version each draft with a date stamp so the latest is never in doubt.
- Never overwrite a filed document; archive it instead.

Filing steps

Step	Action
1	Draft the complaint or motion for custody
2	Assemble the parenting affidavit and the proposed parenting plan
3	Track the responsive pleading deadline and any temporary hearing
4	Prepare exhibits and a clean chronology for the attorney
5	Confirm service and file the certificate of service

Deadline discipline

- Calendar the responsive pleading deadline the day the complaint is served.
- Track temporary hearing dates and discovery cutoffs in one shared view.
- Build a second read pass before any filing leaves the office.
- Hand offs include a one line status, not a roll call.

Building the chronology

A clean chronology turns a messy file into a clear story the attorney can scan in minutes. It grows with the case, one dated line at a time, and every entry points to the document that supports it. When the hearing arrives, the chronology and the exhibit index do most of the work.

Exhibits and adoption crossover

- Number exhibits early and keep an index the attorney can scan fast.
- Pair every affidavit with its supporting documents.
- Carry the same standard into adoption matters, where consent and home study records need equal care.
- A junior paralegal leads the adoption sub batch with a second read.

Before a filing leaves the office

Check	Confirmed by
Document set complete and indexed	Assigned paralegal
Second read pass done	Reviewing paralegal
Service plan and deadline calendared	Senior paralegal
Certificate of service prepared	Assigned paralegal

A clean file is the difference between a calm hearing and a scramble. Consistency is what makes it trustworthy under pressure.